Uncertain Times

On 9 February 1984, Yuri Andropov died of a chronic kidney ailment after less than fifteen months in the job. When a four-day period of official mourning ended, he was succeeded by 72-year-old Konstantin Chernenko, a sharp-tongued geriatric, suffering from emphysema and cirrhosis of the liver. Temperamentally, Chernenko was Honecker's opposite, a dour-faced, analytical politician who mastered the detailed complexities of policy, and was never happy to let others lead or influence him. Worse still, he loathed Honecker's arrogance and East Germany's ambitious foreign policy, and was especially critical of the First Secretary's plans for a five-day visit to Bonn, scheduled for late September.

Having watched warming relations between the two Germanys with suspicion, the old Russian fretted about the GDR's increasing financial dependence on the Federal Republic, fearing Helmut Kohl was trying to foster a pan-Germanic national identity to supersede socialist solidarity.

To spook the SED leadership, Chernenko engineered a sharp article in Pravda attacking Honecker for accepting credit from West German banks in return for easing restrictions on travel between East and West Germany.1 Having listened calmly to Moscow's reservations, Honecker stood firmly by his intention to visit Bonn, a move which led Pravda to follow-up with a second rebuke, under the banner headline: 'On the wrong path', which accused Bonn of using an economic lever to change the post-war order in Europe and destabilise the GDR. In Bonn, the Chief government spokesman, Peter Boenisch, sharply denied a report in Bild claiming FRG Foreign Minister, Hans-Dietrich Genscher, was preparing an 'emergency flight' to Moscow to save the Honecker visit.2 However, when the West German Minister of State, Philip Jenninger, worriedly picked up the phone to ask Honecker directly about the visit, he reportedly replied: 'The GDR's foreign policy is made in Berlin and not in Moscow.' Despite his bluster, the die was cast in the Kremlin on 17 August, when the Soviet leader delivered Honecker a thorough dressing down.